



Interrogative Flip revisited: adding evidentiality to biased polar questions

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OVERVIEW

Korean Long Negation (LN) Polar Questions (PQs) demonstrate peculiar ambiguity in terms of bias interpretations. Adding the evidential dimension resolves this ambiguity puzzle and presents another. Using commitment-based formal pragmatic models, puzzles are resolved by paying attention to different **sentential forces**.

- By adding an evidential dimension, the source of **negative bias** in epistemically positively biased PQs is explained;
- Even for epistemically biased PQs, **contextual evidence** matters;
- Two corollaries:
 1. Epistemic bias and interrogative flip are not incompatible (pace [1])
 2. Semantics of **conjectural questions** is also derived *true-to-form*.

Tense and bias in Korean LN-PQs

Korean LN-PQs can be matrix- or embedded-tense marked. Matrix LN-PQ, (1), is the default case: its interpretation is ambiguous between *p*-biased and $\neg p$ -biased readings; [4]. Embedded LN-PQ is more marked and only paraphrasable as *p*-biased, 2 (see [8]).

- (1) **Matrix LN-PQ** (tense in the matrix clause if present)
 John-i phathi-ey o-ci anh-ass-ni?
 John-NOM party-to come-COMP NEG.do-PST-Q
 ≈ ‘Didn’t John come to the party?’ (*p*-biased)
 ≈ ‘Did John not come to the party?’ ($\neg p$ -biased)
- (2) **Embedded LN-PQ**
 John-i phathi-ey o-ass-ci anh-(ass)-ni?
 John-NOM party-to come-PST-COMP NEG.do-(PST)-Q
 ≈ ‘Didn’t John come to the party?’ (**only p-biased**)

A direct evidential (-te-) tense-marked LN-PQ is $\neg p$ -biased:

- (3) **Evidential LN-PQ**
 John-i phathi-ey o-ci anh-ass-te-ni?
 John-NOM party-to come-COMP NEG.do-PST-TE-Q
 ≈ ‘John did not come to the party?’ ($\neg p$ -biased)
 Not-At-Issue (NAI): ‘Did you perceive John’s absence at the party?’

Inner Negation PQs and contextual evidence

[6] famously subcategorized English High Negation PQs into Outer Negation and Inner Negation PQs. In a contradictory scenario as in (4), other contextually sensitive (negative) PQs are also licensed:

- (4) A: There’s not really any place to go in Hyde Park for dining.
 B: Oh, really, **isn’t** there a(ny) vegetarian restaurant around here?
 B’: Oh, really, **there’s no** vegetarian restaurant around here?
 B'': Oh, really, **is there no** vegetarian restaurant around here?

Evidential Declarative Question Puzzle

Changing the sentence-final particle from the Q-particle (-ni) to a plain declarative (-e) with a final rise (↑) retains the ambiguity of the question bias (compare to 4B and 4B’).

- (5) John-i phathi-ey o-ci anh-ass-e↑?
 ≈ ‘Didn’t John come to P?’ or ‘John did not come to P?’

The equivalent change with Evidential LN-PQ (using -te-compatible declarative morpheme) leads to a pragmatic oddity:

- (6) ??John-i phathi-ey o-ci anh-ass-te-la↑?
 ≈ ‘John did not come to the party.’
 NAI: ‘I think I perceived John’s absence at the party.’
 (Intended NAI:) ‘Did you perceive John’s absence at the party??’

- (7) **Evidential Declarative Question Puzzle**
 - i. The Origo is fixed to the speaker (SPK);
 - ii. It is not a contextual infelicity (adding some $\neg p$ -evidence from the addressee (ADR) in the immediately preceding discourse renders an even more odd discourse);
 - iii. It can be discourse starters (unlike typical Evidential LN-PQs);
 - iv. As NAI shows, the evidential proposition has a weakened propositional meaning, adding a conjectural flavor to it.

Proposal (simplified version)

Based on formal pragmatic models of [3, 7, 1]:

- *p*-biased LN-PQs are **polar interrogatives**: update ADR’s prospective commitment set ($DC_{ADR}^* = DC_{ADR} \cap \{p\}$). E.g. **Embedded LN-PQs**.
- $\neg p$ -biased LN-PQs are **declarative questions** (DecQs): Per [3], SPK of DecQs make commitments, *contingent* on ADR’s ratification, hence the questioning effect. To shift the commitment to ADR, the LN (*anh*-) is trivially composed into the prejacent. E.g. **Evidential LN-PQs**.

Per [3]’s Source Principle (=commitment have sources), SPK identifies ADR as the *source* (epistemic authority) of the $\neg p$ -commitment.

True-to-form solutions

1. Canonical evidential questions, (3):
 Evidentiality in questions leads to a clash of *independent sourcehood*: $source_{EVIDENTIAL} = SPK$, $source_Q = ADR$. **Interrogative Flip (IF)** resolves this epistemic clash (cf. [5]). [-te-Q] form inevitably derives IF.
2. Puzzling evidential declarative questions, (6):
 - The puzzle in (7) is due to **lack of IF**; Updating with [-te-DEC] is just like making a plain evidential assertions ($DC_{SPK}' = DC_{SPK} \cap \{\neg p\}$). Following [1], updating with [↑] is marking SPK’s own prospective *p*-commitment ($DC_{SPK}^* = DC_{SPK} \cap \{\neg p\}$).
 - The observed pragmatic oddity is because of the attempt to update the present and prospective commitment sets with a single utterance.

Epistemic bias and IF *can* be compatible!

Korean PQs counter [1]’s IF typology (‘bias and IF cannot co-occur’):

- An **IF-type language**: both the evidential and the Q operator mark discourse dependency (ADR = independent source)
- Also, an **intonational language** (with ability to mark a neutral PQ with declarative syntax + ↑, **updating** DC_{SPK}^*): [-e↑] ending is felicitous in contexts where SPK lacks evidence for the prejacent:

- (8) A has been sitting in a windowless room. B enters, A asks B:
 pakk-ey pi-ka o-a?
 outside-at rain-NOM come-DEC↑
 ‘Is it raining outside?’

Contra [1], **bias** and **IF** can indeed co-occur in Korean evidential PQs.

- (9) **Ceiling fan example**
 A couple is discussing about the recent remodeling of their apartment. ADR says ‘there’s not much that is upgraded in our apartment.’ SPK reacts to this:
 Silingpayn koayncanh-ci anh-te-na? (... I thought it was nice.)
 ceiling.fan be.fine-COMP NEG.do-TE-Q↑
 ≈ ‘The ceiling fan isn’t nice?’
 NAI: ‘Your observation is that the (changed) ceiling fan isn’t nice?’

There is no *a priori* reason why holding bias (SPK’s previous mental state) and attending to ADR’s sourcehood should be incompatible. Cf. how to resolve epistemic conflict in contradictory scenarios; [9].

Semantics of conjectural questions derived *true-to-form*

- (10) Verb-final *wohl* questions in German ([2], p.28)
 A: I haven’t had any news about Peter in a long time.
 B: Me neither.
 A: Ob er wohl immer noch Zigarren mag?
 whether he wohl still PRT cigars likes
 ‘I wonder whether he still likes cigars’
- (11) Proposed LF for the verb-final *wohl* CQ by [2]
 [lob [ForceP wohl] [SpecCP - [C' - [IP ? er - immer noch Zigarren mag]]]]

References

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